

Instructor: Date:

Learner: Regional Branch:

Program: Center:

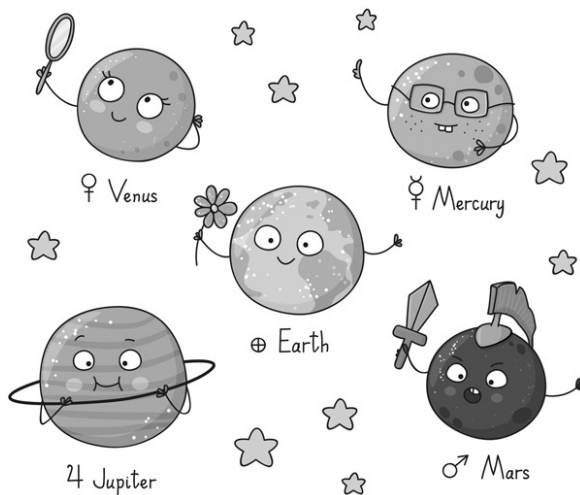
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Let's Start!

The planet is going retrograde!



Learning Outcome

Exchange information about hypothetical situations in written and spoken interactions according to work and social contexts.

Ask your partner:

- What do you know about astronomy and the planets?
- Do you think it is possible for the other planets to affect what happens on Earth? Why or why not?

Can Do Statements

- I can discuss coincidences and strange events.
- I can say what happened and what was happening, what had happened, and what had been happening.
- I can speculate about the past.

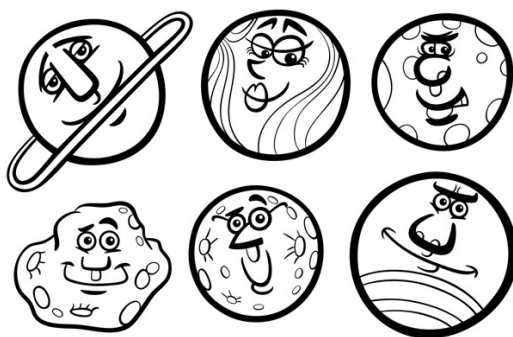




Let's Explore!

The planet Mercury **rules*** communication!

* To "rule" means to control.



Instructions: Read the text aloud.

Vanessa: Peter ... what did you say about Mercury back there?

Peter: I said Mercury's in retrograde. That explains the problems I've been having. If I had remembered that, I wouldn't have bothered to go to the shop. The tech must have thought I was crazy.

Vanessa: What are you talking about?

Peter: The planet Mercury rules communication, clear thinking, truth and travel, so when the planet goes retrograde - which means that it looks like it's going backwards in the sky — all those things go backwards. It happens for a couple of weeks, three times a year.

Vanessa : Okay. But what does this have to do with your phone and computer?

Peter: Well, if communication is going backwards then that might have been why my texts weren't being sent. When Mercury is in retrograde, things get a bit crazy.

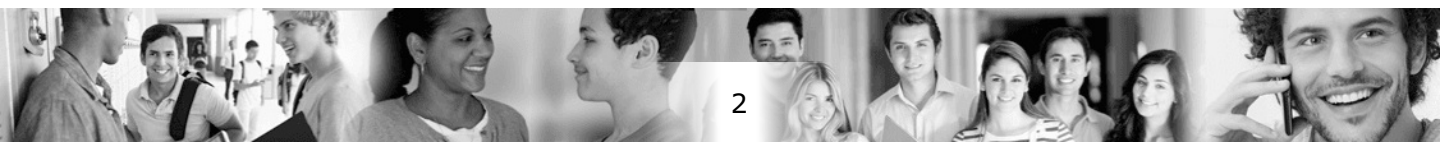
Vanessa: Do you really believe that?

Peter: Yes! Last time Mercury was in retrograde, I was on my way to New York. I was traveling by train and I got to the station early. I was reading my book and waiting to board when I heard an announcement. A huge snowstorm had hit Washington and the train that was supposed to take us to New York got stuck in a snow drift! I tried to rent a car but the police had shut down the highways. I called the airlines but they had been cancelling flights all day. I waited for 2 hours to get a taxi that I had to share with 4 strangers. Wow! You must have been exhausted.

Vanessa: I was. But I remember someone in the taxi talking about Mercury retrograde. He must have been an astronomy student.

Vanessa: That kind of snowstorm is not unusual on the East coast. What makes you think it was caused by a planet going backwards?

Peter: It was September.





Let's Practice!

Peter tells Vanessa a very interesting experience he had on a trip.

Instructions: Read the text on page 2 again. Select all the correct options.

Which of the following statements are correct?

- 1) Peter was in New York when all the events happened.
- 2) Peter was getting on board when he heard the announcement.
- 3) A snowstorm had hit Washington.
- 4) Peter's train got stuck in a snow drift.
- 5) A policeman stopped Peter's car.
- 6) The police had shut down the highways.
- 7) Peter waited for a long time for a taxi.



Let's Practice!

Peter speculates about the past.

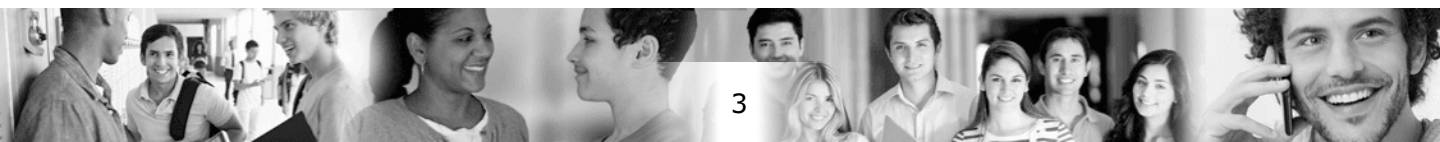
Instructions: Match the statements from Column A to the ones on Column B. Read the complete sentences aloud. Check your pronunciation with your instructor.

COLUMN A

1. If I had remembered that,
2. If communication is going backwards then
3. You must have been exhausted
4. He must have been an astronomy student,
5. I might have been a bit confused

COLUMN B

- a. I wouldn't have bothered to go to the shop.
- b. he knew a lot about planets.
- c. after all those unusual things that happened to you.
- d. after all those events; it was a crazy day.
- e. that might have been why my texts weren't being sent.





Extension Activity

Write a story about a travel disaster.

Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.

- Think about a trip that you took that had lots of problems.
- Write a story about the experience and all the things that went wrong. (If you can't think of a true story, make one up.)
- Exchange stories with a partner.
- Read your partner's story and correct any errors you find.

Self-Assessment

Yes

No

I write a story about a travel disaster.

☐ ☐

I read a partner's story.

☐ ☐

I make corrections to my partner's story.

☐ ☐


Target Words

- Mercury** (noun): the planet nearest to the sun
e.g. What did you say about Mercury back there?
- retrograde** (noun): an illusion in which a planet appears to be traveling backward
e.g. I said Mercury's in retrograde.
- backwards** (adverb): movement away from one's front
e.g. It looks like it's going backwards in the sky.
- to have to do with something** (expression): involved or connected with
e.g. But what does this have to do with your phone and computer?
- to not bother to do something** (expression): to make no effort to do something
e.g. If I had remembered that, I wouldn't have bothered to go to the shop.
- snow drift** (noun): a deep bank of snow heaped by the wind
e.g. The train that was supposed to take us to New York got stuck in a snow drift!
- snowstorm** (noun): a storm which brings a lot of snow and strong winds
e.g. That kind of snowstorm is not unusual on the East coast.





Learning Points

The Narrative Tenses: Simple Past, Past Continuous, Past Perfect and Past Perfect Continuous

Narrative tenses are the tenses that you use to talk about past events and to tell stories.

The most common narrative tense is the Simple Past. Three other tenses, Past Continuous, the Past Perfect and the Past Perfect Continuous can help you say what you want more efficiently.

It is often useful to look at these tenses together within the context of the function narrating, i.e. relating past events.

Tense	Use	Example
Simple Past	Completed Actions/ Routines in the past	<i>I was on my way to New York. I waited for two hours to get a taxi that I had to share with four strangers.</i>
Past Continuous	Actions in progress in the past/background story/two actions happening at the same time in the past	<i>I was reading my book and waiting to board when I heard an announcement.</i>
Past Perfect	An action that happened before another past action	<i>A huge snow storm had hit Washington and the train that was supposed to take us to New York got stuck in a snow drift!</i>
Past Perfect Continuous	An action that was in progress before another past action	<i>I called the airlines but they had been cancelling flights all day.</i>





Learning Points

Speculating About the Past

You use Perfect modals to speculate about things that happened in the past. Speculation means guessing about what happened in the past.

You form the Perfect modals by using this structure:

subject + modal + *have* + past participle

For example:

*The tech **must have thought** I was crazy.*

Here, *must have* implies a strong certainty that the tech thought they were crazy.

*That **might have been** why my texts weren't being sent.*

Here, *might have* implies less certainty about what happened in the past.

Examples:

- *The tech must have thought I was crazy.*
- *That might have been why my texts weren't being sent.*
- *You must have been exhausted.*
- *He must have been an astronomy student.*
- *If I had remembered that, I wouldn't have bothered to go to the shop.*

